GEORGE ORWELL'S

ANIMAL FARM

IS IT WRITTEN DOWN ANYWHERE?

memory, records & power — a close reading

THE STORY

The animals of Manor Farm drive out their drunken owner and paint Seven Commandments on the barn wall: all animals are equal. Slowly the pigs take control, and the rules quietly change. By the last page the other animals can no longer tell the pigs from the humans.

MY ARGUMENT · The pigs never have to win an argument. They decide what gets written down, quietly change it when it suits them, and let the other animals doubt their own memories. In Orwell's farm, *whoever holds the paintbrush holds the past.*

MY QUESTION

Why do the animals give up their own memories so easily?

THE SEVEN COMMANDMENTS

1. Whatever goes upon two legs is an enemy.
2. Whatever goes upon four legs, or has wings, is a friend.
3. No animal shall wear clothes.
4. No animal shall sleep in a bed WITH SHEETS.
5. No animal shall drink alcohol TO EXCESS.
6. No animal shall kill any other animal WITHOUT CAUSE.
7. ~~All animals are equal.~~ BUT SOME ANIMALS ARE MORE EQUAL THAN OTHERS

red = painted in later, at night



NAPOLEON

holds the paintbrush. Never argues — he just controls the record.





BOXER

never gets past the letter D. "Napoleon is always right."



BENJAMIN

reads as well as any pig — and says nothing.



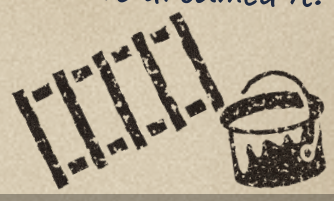
THE SHEEP

can't learn seven rules, so they chant "Four legs good, two legs bad!"



SQUEALER

"Is it written down anywhere?" If not, you must have dreamed it.



Ch. VIII: Squealer falls off a ladder at night, next to a pot of white paint. Days later rule 5 reads "to excess".

ONE MEMORY, REWRITTEN...

CH. IV · THE BATTLE

Snowball is the hero of the battle: Animal Hero, First Class.

CH. VII · SQUEALER

"That was our mistake, comrade." He was Jones's agent all along.

CH. IX · THE FINAL RECORD

His wounds were "inflicted by Napoleon's teeth."

My review: *Animal Farm*

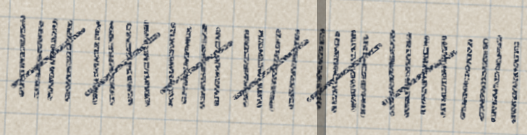
★★★★★ · SEPT 2026

I went into *Animal Farm* expecting a history lesson in costume: Napoleon is Stalin, Snowball is Trotsky, the windmill is the Five-Year Plan. That reading is accurate, and it's the one most of us get taught. But by the last page, I felt it undersold the book. What unsettled me wasn't the parallel to 1917. It was how easily the animals were talked out of their own memories.

Look at who can read on this farm. The pigs read perfectly. Muriel manages. Clover learns the alphabet but can't put words together. Boxer, the strongest and most loyal animal, never gets past the letter D, and the sheep can't hold even the Seven Commandments in their heads. So Snowball shrinks the whole philosophy into "Four [illegible] good, two legs bad." It looks like a kind [illegible] a way to include everyone. It's actually [illegible] first step toward a population that can [illegible] chant.

The line that stayed with me m[illegible] Squealer's question when the animals [illegible] remember a resolution against trade: [illegible] written down anywhere?" It isn't, s[illegible] decide they must have dreamed it. Afte[illegible] the Commandments are quietly [illegible] Nobody lies about the past outright. Th[illegible] just make sure the written record is t[illegible] past that counts, and then they h[illegible] paintbrush.

My review got 34 replies from classmates:



15 pushed back. The best correction:

"The animals aren't short of text. They're short of control over it."

READ IN 2026

Surrounded by edited posts and screenshots of claims that later vanish, the book feels less like a fable about Soviet Russia and more like a manual for anyone who controls the archive.

"...already it was impossible to say which was which." — the last line, Ch. X

THE CENTRAL IDEA The animals don't lose the farm in one night. They lose it the moment they agree that *if it isn't written down, it didn't happen.*

SOURCES: George Orwell, *Animal Farm: A Fairy Story* (Secker & Warburg, 1945), all quotations · my own review of the novel and its 34 classmate replies (2026) · linocut-style prints adapted from game-icons.net (CC BY 3.0) and Microsoft Fluent Emoji (MIT).

by Sayanjeet